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FREE CHECKLIST · 2026 EDITION

Payment Gateway Setup Cheat Sheet (With Expert Tips)

Our free Payment Gateway Setup Cheat Sheet walks you through the 5 simple steps to get paid online. Download your expert tips and start selling today!



6 pages · PDF

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What's inside

3 short sections. Read it in order, or jump to the part you need today.

01 Your 5-Step Payment Gateway Setup Checklist

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Feeling stuck on how to actually get paid for your online sales? You're not alone. Setting up payments can seem technical and confusing, but it doesn't have to be.

This cheat sheet breaks it down into five simple, actionable steps. Follow this guide, and you'll have a secure payment system ready for your first customer in no time.

01 Your 5-Step Payment Gateway Setup Checklist

Think of this as your pre-flight checklist before you launch your online store.

Step 1: Choose Your Payment Gateway

- The Task: Pick the service that will process your customer's card payments.
- How-To: For most beginners, the easiest path is to use the gateway recommended by your website platform (like Shopify, WooCommerce, etc.). It's usually pre-integrated, saving you a huge headache.
- Expert Tip: Start Simple. Don't get paralyzed by comparing 20 different providers. If you're on Shopify, start with Shopify Payments. If you're on WooCommerce, consider Stripe or PayPal. You can always add more options later.

Step 2: Create Your Business Account

- The Task: Sign up for a business account with your chosen payment gateway. Do NOT use a personal account.
- How-To: Go to the provider's website (e.g., Stripe.com, PayPal.com/Business) and click "Sign Up." You'll be guided through the process.
- Expert Tip: Have Your Details Ready. You'll need your legal business name, address, and Employer Identification Number (EIN) or Social Security Number (SSN) (for sole proprietors). Having this on hand makes the process smooth.

Step 3: Verify Your Account & Identity

- The Task: Prove to the payment gateway that your business is legitimate. This is a security must-do.
- How-To: The provider will guide you. This usually involves confirming your email, phone number, and sometimes providing business documentation.
- Expert Tip: Be Patient. Verification can sometimes take a few days. Do this step *before* you launch to avoid any last-minute delays when you get your first order.

Step 4: Connect Your Bank Account

- The Task: Tell the payment gateway where to send your money.
- How-To: In your gateway's dashboard, find the "Payouts" or "Bank Accounts" section. You'll need your bank's routing number and your account number.
- Expert Tip: Use a Business Bank Account. Keeping your business and personal finances separate is a cornerstone of professional and legal protection. It also makes accounting much easier.

Step 5: Connect the Gateway to Your Online Store

- The Task: Make the "Buy Now" button on your website talk to your payment gateway.
- How-To: This is often the most technical-sounding step, but platforms have made it very simple. Go to your website admin panel (e.g., your Shopify or WooCommerce settings), find "Payments," and follow the instructions to connect or "activate" your chosen gateway.
- Expert Tip: Test Before You Go Live! Most gateways have a "Test Mode." Use it to place a fake order to ensure the entire process, from clicking "buy" to receiving a confirmation email, works perfectly.

02 Expert Security & Fraud Prevention Tips

Once you're set up, protecting your hard-earned money is crucial. Here are three non-negotiable tips.

1. Turn On Your Gateway's Built-In Fraud Tools.
    - Services like Stripe Radar and PayPal's Seller Protection are your first line of defense. Go into your settings and make sure they are enabled. They use advanced systems to block suspicious transactions automatically.
2. Always Ship to the "Verified Address."
    - Your payment gateway checks if the customer's billing address matches their card. If a customer insists you ship to a different, unverified address, consider it a major red flag and cancel the order.
3. Be Wary of Large, Rushed International Orders.
    - While expanding globally is a great goal, be extra cautious with high-value orders from countries known for high fraud rates, especially if the customer is urgently pushing for shipment.

03 Your Quick-Reference Cheat Sheet

Print this out and stick it on your wall!

Step	Task	Key Question to Ask	Status
1	Choose Gateway	"What's the easiest option for my website platform?"	☐
2	Create Business Account	"Do I have my EIN/SSN and business info ready?"	☐
3	Verify Identity	"Have I completed all the verification steps?"	☐
4	Connect Bank Account	"Is my business bank account linked?"	☐
5	Connect to Store & TEST	"Did I place a successful test order?"	☐

You've got this! By following this structured approach, you're not just installing a piece of software, you're building a secure, reliable financial foundation for your business. Now go get that first sale!

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